

HUNTED

THE DEMON'S FORGE

Faiyaz Shaikh

readersletters@thinkdigit.com

Hunted: The Demon's Forge follows the adventures of a mercenary duo of Caddoc and E'lara, whose quest for wealth leads them into the dark and hostile world of Kala Moor. Caddoc is a burly, bald-headed human who prefers responding to hostilities with a sword and a shield in the face; whereas E'lara, in keeping with long standing Elfish tradition, prefers the bow and arrows. The pair is first provoked into the quest by Caddoc's disturbing nightmare, to be eventually led on by the mysterious Seraphine and prospects of significant wealth. The game's overall plot is pretty thin and is something that we have seen numerous times in games set in a fantasy world. The world is under threat by an ancient and powerful evil and a pair of unlikely heroes is all that can save the day. This game gets away with such a tired plot because the game-play, although not inspiring, is totally playable and to some degree even engaging.

Despite the game's fantasy setting and character progression system that is generally found in role-playing games, Hunted is essentially an action game. It is played from a third-person perspective and its combat uses a cover-system. Caddoc and E'lara can engage in melee and ranged combat; however, the former's crossbow and latter's sword is meant to be used only in dire situations. Typically, Caddoc will hold the frontlines while E'lara takes pot-shots from behind. The game has been designed as a multiplayer co-op affair, but it works fairly well even in single-player mode with AI controlled partner. The game's set-pieces are designed much like a shooter, wherein waves of cannon fodder class enemies are often followed by a boss fight. Fallen enemies drop items, gold and crystal fragments. These crystals are used to unlock new skills for the two characters and to upgrade existing ones. Magical weapons are strewn across the dungeons of Kala Moor, but these have limited charges and work much like ordinary weapons after the magic in them has been depleted.

Sticking to the main game-plan of countering enemies with Caddoc's melee and E'lara ranged skills will lead the player to the final goal without too much effort or frustration. Once the game has been beaten, you can get more value out of it in a couple of ways. Completing the single-player campaign unlocks the new game+ mode that you could play on the same difficulty level or beat the game on a higher difficulty level, since by now you are likely to have a greater understanding of the game's mechanics and enemies. Hunted ships with a very basic level creator/editor called Crucible, assets for which have to be unlocked by collecting gold in the main game. If you are not the creator type, then downloading Crucible levels created by other players is also an option.

Hunted: The Demon's Forge does not offer anything that is truly memorable, but at the same time it is not a bad game either. This game may not be worthy of full price; however, with a bargain it heeds consideration as a game with decent co-op action.

